

defence

ARJUN TANKS

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

Space is at a premium at the Heavy Vehicles Factory (HVF) in Avadi on the outskirts of Chennai. But these are no ordinary motor cars which need parking. Rows of battle tanks lie jammed, spilling out of the factory premises. Parking a monster that is the size of a city bus but at 60 tonne weighs heavier than a railway coach, is no easy task. Ordnance Factory Board (OFB) officials have asked for parking space at the nearby Combat Vehicles R&D Establishment (CVRDE) that designed the tank, even as they worry about sheltering their monsters and its electronics from the elements.

In the past four years, over 90 Arjun

a white elephant into an extreme battle machine worthy of its moniker. So far 15 Pre-Production Series (PPS) tanks have completed a cumulative 80,000 km, or the equivalent of two trips around the world, and fired over 8,000 rounds. Two tanks covering over 6,000 km or nearly twice the distance they are supposed to cover in 10 years. Now, the army is poring over the trial reports to decide whether the crowded tank lot at Avadi will equip at least three of the army's 61 armoured regiments.

There's just a catch. The army has pronounced its verdict. It wants more tanks—armoured fists that are used to punch through enemy lines and an essential component of its Cold Start battle strategy—but it does not want the Arjun. Speaking at a recent CII seminar

on the Future Main Battle Tank (FMBT), Lt General Dalip Bharadwaj, director-general, Mechanised Forces said the army will not place orders for Arjun beyond the 124 already on order because it is "now looking 20 years ahead and wants a futuristic MBT".

His predecessor, Lt General (retd.) K.D.S. Shekhawat is blunter. "The DRDO does not want to own up, the Arjun is based on the German Army's Leopard-1 design which entered service in the mid-1960s. It outlived its life over a decade ago. Today, every tank in the world, including the Leopard-2 and T-90, have sloped turrets (to reduce the impact of a hit) but the Arjun still continues with the rectangular turret."

The DRDO is combative and not only because the project is the baby of the

ALL DRESSED UP...

After 25 years in development, the prestigious Arjun battle tank comes out all guns blazing but with the army reluctant to place more orders, it faces an uncertain future

main battle tanks have rolled off the production line that made India's first indigenous tank—part of an order for 124 tanks that was placed six years ago. In late August this year, the army completed nearly a year of what it calls Accelerated User Cum Reliability Trials (AUCRT) and somewhat unprecedented, extended trials in the desert of Rajasthan. Trials that tested the three characteristics of any battle tank—firepower, mobility and protection. From all accounts the tank finally morphed from

**UNWANTED:
The Arjun Tank**

